




**CALL FOR TRUTH** Protesters at Parade Ground, Dehradun, demanding justice in the 2022 Ankita Bhandari murder case, Feb. 8

▶ UTTARAKHAND

# NIRBHAYA OF THE HILLS

**Three years after a murder, a trial and convictions, Uttarakhand is still roiled by the Ankita Bhandari case. A CBI probe now pursues claims about a 'VIP' hand**

around old-world noblesse is at stake.

Ankita was just 19, the daughter of a former security guard and an anganwadi worker. Having completed Class 12, she wanted to go to college. But with her father retired for years and the family under financial strain, she took up work as a receptionist at a resort on the outskirts of Rishikesh. It was meant to be a short stop, a means to steady things at home while perhaps saving enough for college later. She never lived long enough to collect her first salary.

Six days after Ankita went missing in September 2022, the police recovered her body from a canal. Investigators said she was under pressure to provide "extra services" to "VIP" guests at the resort, something she resisted.

The mass outrage that followed soon made the case a focal point of Uttarakhand politics. The main accused, resort owner Pulkit Arya, was the son of former BJP minister Vinod Arya. Pulkit—arrested along with manager Saurabh Bhaskar and another man, Ankit—confessed to pushing Ankita into the canal after an altercation. In May 2025, a court in Kotdwar convicted the trio, sentencing all three to life imprisonment. Back in September 2022, the BJP had expelled Vinod Arya and his older son from the party.

But none of this brought real closure. Even after arrests, a high-profile trial and convictions, allegations of selective omissions, political shielding and influence continued to surface, helping keep the case alive in public discourse. Now, over three years after Ankita's murder, the case has returned to the centre of political conversations, triggered by fresh claims that a senior BJP leader may have been involved.

Breaking the official omerta code that usually subjects such cases to a slow strangulation, these fresh angles surfaced after a series of social media disclosures in late December: a Facebook Live session and subsequent videos posted by Urmila Sanawar, who claims to be the second wife of Suresh Rathore, an ex- BJP MLA from Haridwar.

## DISCLOSURE DRAMA

It was not entirely free of click-baiting melodrama—as her clips went viral, Urmila went into hiding, claiming a threat to life, releasing more clips from undisclosed locations, castigating the FIRs filed against her (on the veracity of her original claims) as part of it. She returned only after being assured of security by the government. But the claims she had made were dark enough—hinting at the alleged involvement of "VIP" figures—to stir anger all over again in civil society.

January was thus marked by a fresh wave of protests, now coalescing under a larger grouping called the 'Save Uttarakhand' movement. The welling up of such collectivised moral rage was comparable to the Nirbhaya movement in Delhi or the RG Kar protests of Kolkata. The particulars of the case reveal why: they share the key plot elements,